Security Basics

These basics apply to everyone at Pebblebrook Studio, in the north, harbour and east offices. They cost very little time and prevent most of the problems the IT desk sees. If you are ever unsure whether something is safe, ask the desk through the support form before you act.

1. Never share your password

Your password belongs to you. The IT desk never asks for a password by chat, email or phone, and nobody at the desk will ask you to read one out or to type it into a message. If someone asks for your password and says they are from IT, treat the request as suspicious and report it.

Passwords must be at least 14 characters and are changed every 12 months. You reset a password yourself on the self-service account portal, which takes about 5 minutes. A locked account unlocks by itself after 15 minutes.

2. Lock your screen when you leave your desk

Lock your screen every time you step away, even for a short coffee break. A screen left open in a shared room is an easy way for someone to read files they should not see, or to send a message in your name. Your laptop's lock shortcut takes one key press, so the habit is quick to build.

At the end of the day, shut the laptop down or put it in a locked drawer if you have one. Do not leave laptops on desks in the reception areas overnight.

3. Report suspicious messages

A suspicious message is one that asks you to click a link you did not expect, to open an attachment you were not waiting for, or to send money, codes or credentials. Phishing messages often look like they come from a colleague, a supplier or the IT desk itself. If you are not sure, do not reply and do not click.

Report the message through the support form, and include the sender name, the subject line and a short description of what it asked you to do. Do not forward the message to other colleagues. The desk will tell you whether it is safe to delete it. If you already clicked a link or entered a password, report it at once so that the desk can act quickly.

4. Never plug in an unknown USB stick

USB sticks and external drives are a common way for malware to reach a computer. Do not plug in a stick you found on a desk, in a meeting room or in the post, even if it looks harmless. If you need to move files between machines, use the file share or email instead.

If a colleague hands you a stick, ask the desk to scan it before you open anything on it.

5. Keep your software current

The company image is updated by the desk and applies changes overnight. Please allow the restart when it asks, so the update can finish. A laptop that never restarts misses important protection updates.

6. Use the right network

Connect your laptop to the staff network named for your office. Guests should use the guest network for their office, the code for which is on the reception card and changes every Monday. Please do not give the guest code to people who are not visiting the studio, and do not connect company laptops to unknown networks while travelling. If you must, use the VPN before you open any company file.

7. Back up your work

Work saved to the file share is backed up every night from 01:00 to 02:00, and a deleted file can be restored for 30 days. Files kept only on your desktop are not backed up. Save important work to the file share, and ask the desk if you are not sure where your team keeps its files.

8. When in doubt, ask

Nobody is expected to know every rule. If something feels wrong, stop, do not click, and open a ticket on the support form. The desk would much rather hear about a false alarm than miss a real problem.